ANIL KAPOOR ▶
Actor

A STAR FOR ALL SEASONS



Anil Kapoor is inching close to 70, but his star shows no sign of waning. Lead roles continue, the latest being *Subedaar*, where his silent, angry man turn has drawn attention. Longevity, he said at the India Today conclave, comes from clarity. "I've never been delusional about anything in my life.... The roles I have been doing are that which suit my age." The alternative, he noted, is harsher: better to be asked 'Why are you playing the father's role? You look young compared to the hero' than hear the audience say 'What are you doing? Look at your age'. Even so, how does he manage to look so young and fit—43 years after *Woh 7 Din*? By giving his younger peers a run for their money in the gymnasium.

Such a long career also necessitates reinvention, a certain evolution in one's craft, even if you have won two National Film Awards, multiple Filmfare Awards and been part of an Oscar and Screen Actors Guild Award winning team. How does he approach that? Kapoor's method is simple: stay curious. "I'm a good listener and I listen to people who are much more sensible, much more intelligent," he said. He watches films, travels and works with younger directors. The instinct is to avoid repetition. "There's always a conscious decision to do something new.... I'm ready to fail." Some risks, he admits, do not land immediately, but "will stand the test of time".

That instinct has shaped a four-decade career built on filmmakers and stories rather than formulas. "It was always the filmmaker and the gut for a good story," he said, recalling collaborations across generations. Early on, Kapoor engineered his own breakthrough. In an era of clean-shaven heroes, he chose a moustache and stubble to age up into roles he was being denied. The look

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Kapoor arrived at a time when most actors opted for a clean-shaven look. Deemed too young for parts in the late '70s and early '80s, he grew a stubble. That and the moustache soon became synonymous with his persona**
- **Kapoor is deliberate about not repeating himself. Not every gamble works, he says, but he backs his instinct, believing some may not connect now but "will stand the test of time"**